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Introducing illusionism

Keith Frankish

1. The old woman and the beetle

You are in a busy city in a country you have never visited before. An old woman in a colourful dress emerges from the crowd, smiling and holding something out to you. She tells you to take it and examine it. Intrigued, you do so. It is a small wooden box with a hinged lid, a clasp, and a peephole in the top. It is completely empty. The woman tells you to close the lid, fasten the clasp, and hold the box tight. She waves her hands around, utters an incantation, then invites you to look through the peephole. You are startled to see a huge, iridescent beetle inside. The woman repeats her performance and tells you to open the box. As before, it is empty. The woman takes back the box, smiles, and waits patiently for a tip.

It seems that the woman did something miraculous, remotely transporting a beetle into and out of a sealed box. What would you think? You would have three broad options. First, you might accept that the episode really was miraculous and that the woman had paranormal powers. Second, you might assume that there must be a scientific explanation of what happened. Perhaps there was some hidden mechanism that inserted the beetle and removed it. And third, you might suspect that it was an illusion. Perhaps there wasn't really a beetle in the box at all. Maybe the woman just made it *seem* as if there was.

Wouldn't the last option be the most likely one, even if you couldn't imagine how the illusion had been created? At any rate, wouldn't it at least be worth exploring the hypothesis that the beetle was illusory? *Illusionism* about consciousness is the view that we should adopt a similar attitude to the apparent miracle of consciousness.[1]

2. The hard problem of consciousness

Think of what happens when you have a conscious experience — for example, when you sip black coffee, gaze at a blue sky, or stub your toe. Lots of things happen in your nervous system. Receptor cells in your sense organs react to physical

[1] The beetle box story is inspired by a famous passage in Ludwig Wittgenstein's *Philosophical Investigations* (Wittgenstein, 1963, Sec 293, p. 100).

stimuli (chemicals, light, tissue damage, and so on) and send electrochemical signals to your brain. There, sensory regions process the signals, extracting information about the world and the state of your body. This information is then routed to other brain systems, where it is used to control and regulate bodily and mental processes, generating physiological and behavioural responses and a vast array of (mostly unconscious) psychological reactions, which shape how you respond to future stimuli. All of this is immensely complex, involving interactions among billions of brain cells. Nevertheless, in the light of modern science, none of it seems miraculous. Scientists are developing theories of how the brain performs these sensory and control functions, and they are beginning to create artificial systems that can do similar things on a more modest scale.

However, consciousness seems to involve something else, too. Each experience seems to have a subjective quality or 'feel' to it. When you take a sip of coffee, it seems that you are presented with a mental quality — the taste itself — which determines what the experience is *like* for you and how you react. It is as if sensory processes channel their information to an internal arena where these qualities are presented to an inner observer — the inner you, your conscious self. (Daniel Dennett calls this arena the 'Cartesian Theatre', after the seventeenth-century French philosopher René Descartes, who thought that the material brain presented sensory information to the immaterial soul via the pineal gland; Dennett, 1991.) These mental qualities are sometimes called *qualia* or *phenomenal properties*, and mental states that possess them are said to have *phenomenality* or be *phenomenally conscious*.

Now, this does look miraculous. How does the brain produce these qualities, this inner show of colours, sounds, smells, tastes, and bodily sensations? How does the brilliant beetle of phenomenality appear in the wooden box of the brain? This is the *hard problem* of consciousness (Chalmers, 1995), and it looks *really* hard. Note that what needs to be explained is not any of the *abilities* you exercise when you sip the coffee — your ability to recognize the coffee, to compare it to other drinks, to describe it ('bitter and smoky' say), and so on. Nor is it the problem of explaining any of your reactions to the coffee, such as the memories and associations it calls up or the effects it has on your alertness or emotional state. We could explain all *that* by identifying the brain mechanisms that carry out the relevant processes of information gathering and response production, including those that generate verbal reports. What needs to be explained, it seems, is something extra — the felt

essence of the experience, understood as something abstracted from all those informational and control processes. It is hard to see how science could get any grip at all on something so intangible.

The problem is made even harder by the fact that these mental qualities seem to belong to a private world that is completely inaccessible to anyone else. Scientists might map your brain processes in the finest detail, but they would never catch the qualitative essence of your experience. The show in the Cartesian Theatre is for the inner you alone, poised somewhere between the incoming information and the outgoing reactions.

3. Three options

What should we think about this apparent miracle? As with the beetle box, we have three broad options. First, we might accept that phenomenal consciousness cannot be scientifically explained. Maybe our brains have a nonphysical aspect, in addition to the physical aspects described by science. The chief challenge for this approach is to explain how these nonphysical aspects of experience are related to the physical ones, especially since it looks likely that all the *effects* of conscious experience can be explained in physical terms.

Second, we might trust that there must be a scientific explanation of phenomenal consciousness and start theorizing about what it might be, using the resources of the physical sciences. For example, we might try to explain phenomenal consciousness in terms of how the brain represents the world or its own states. The chief problem for this approach is that such theories seem incapable of giving a satisfactory explanation of phenomenality. We can always imagine the proposed mechanisms operating without any subjective feel attached to them.

Third, we might say that the phenomenal aspect of experience is illusory. It seems to be there, but it isn't really. This is the approach that has come to be called *illusionism* (Frankish, 2017). Illusionism completely avoids the hard problem. We don't have to explain how our experiences come to have a private qualitative aspect, since they don't really have one. All we need to explain is why we *think* they have one, and this is a psychological reaction, which can very likely be explained in terms of brain processes. As with the beetle box, isn't this the obvious response to the problem — or at the very least one that we should seriously consider? A number of philosophers have argued so, most famously Daniel Dennett, who has

described illusionism as 'the obvious default theory of consciousness' (Dennett, 2016).[2]

Despite this, however, illusionism remains a minority view, and it is often written off out of hand as *denying consciousness*. The philosopher Galen Strawson calls it 'the Denial' and describes it as 'the silliest view ever held in the history of human thought' (Strawson, 2019, p. 32). Is he right?

4. Does illusionism deny consciousness?

It should be clear from what I have already said that illusionists do not deny the existence of consciousness in the everyday sense. They do not deny that we have conscious experiences of seeing, hearing, feeling, tasting, smelling, of having emotions and moods, of feeling pains and bodily sensations, and so on. They hold that these episodes involve the immensely complex informational and control processes mentioned earlier — processes shaped by billions of years of natural selection to make us sensitive to features of the world that matter to our survival. What illusionists *do* deny is that these episodes also involve awareness of private mental qualities, presented to an inner self.

On their view, conscious experience is essentially an informational process. If we need a metaphor, it would be that of a news report rather than a theatrical show — or, more accurately, a vast collection of news reports, sometimes conflicting, all being told at the same time, as multiple channels of sensory information and interpretation unfold in the brain (Dennett, 1991). Of course, these reports are not in a human language; they are in the brain's internal language of neural signalling. And they are not for the benefit of a conscious reader, an inner you. Sensory systems pass their reports directly to control systems, which generate the host of physiological, psychological, and behavioural responses mentioned earlier. You — the person — are the sum of all this activity. All the underground, 'subpersonal' reporting and controlling enables you to do the things you do, acting and reacting as a person.

If this isn't clear, think of what happens when you are having a lively conversation. You don't rehearse the words before you say them. They come to your lips spontaneously, thanks to subpersonal processes in your brain. They are *your* words (and you'll have to stand by them), but you didn't consciously choose them, and

[2] For Dennett's defence of the position, see, e.g., Dennett, 1988, 1991, 2005. For other defences, see, e.g., Farrell, 1950; Frankish, 2016a, 2016b; Humphrey, 2011; Pereboom, 2011; Rey, 1992; and Rorty, 1965.

you have absolutely no idea how they were produced. (Even if you do rehearse some words to yourself first to see how they sound, these rehearsed words come to you spontaneously.) Most of our behaviour is of this spontaneous kind. (And thank goodness it is. Otherwise we'd never get anything done!)

So, illusionists do reject the idea of an inner show, decked out with phenomenal qualities and presented to an inner observer. And it is true, of course, that some people think that this inner show and its qualities are not only real but the very essence of consciousness. Indeed, idealists think there is nothing else to consciousness, and that it's the brain processes, along with the rest of the physical world, that are illusory (see, e.g., Hoffman 2019). Illusionists do deny the existence of consciousness as these people conceive of it. But, equally, idealists deny the existence of consciousness as illusionists conceive of it. Given this, accusing each other of denying consciousness doesn't look like a profitable way of moving the debate forward. It would be better to say that illusionists and their opponents disagree about what consciousness *is* and get on with working out who is right.

5. Putting the illusion into illusionism

Illusionists deny that consciousness is an inner show and argue that having conscious experiences involves being directly sensitive to the world. But that can't be the whole story, surely? After all, we can think about our experiences as well as about the world. We can recognize our experiences, compare them, say whether we like them, and describe them to other people (say what they are 'like'). Moreover, our experiences seem to possess distinctively *mental* properties. Science tells us that the properties we are aware of in the world often aren't as they appear to be. Colours are really light-reflecting properties of surfaces, sounds are pressure waves in the air, tastes are molecules in our food, and so on. But they appear to us as simple qualities — redness, middle C, coffee taste. Where are these qualities, if not in our minds? What do illusionists say about all this?

Illusionists don't deny that we are aware of our own experiences. We can look inwards — *introspect*. And they don't deny that this can seem like being aware of an inner show, decked out with mental qualities. (The point of calling their view *illusionism* is precisely to acknowledge this point.) However, they hold that introspection misleads us about the nature of our experiences.

As illusionists see it, introspection, like sense perception, depends on subpersonal mechanisms of reporting and reacting. It doesn't involve an inner self with

direct awareness of mental qualities, but just another layer of information processing, this time directed onto other brain processes. Introspective mechanisms monitor the complex informational and reactive processes that constitute our experiences and send information about them to control systems. The brain reports on its own activities as well as on the world outside. And these reports are crafted and edited to suit the needs of the control systems that receive them. Control systems do not need to know all the details of the brain's current informational-reactive state; they just need an outline, which captures the main features — the headlines, as it were. The exact nature and format of these experience reports is a matter for scientific investigation, but they might contain information about what type of experience it is (visual, say), how it is related to other experiences (for example, different from experiences of yellow and of red but somewhat similar to ones of green), and what physiological, psychological, and behavioural reactions it is producing (for example, having a calming effect, evoking memories of summer, and prompting the verbal description 'blue'). Control systems use these reports to generate reactions to the experience in the form of beliefs, utterances, emotional responses, and so on. All this happens at a subpersonal level of course, but the result of it is that you — the person — are sensitive to the nature of your own experiences. Thanks to your introspective systems, you can tell others about your experiences, say whether you liked them, deliberately seek to induce positive experiences, and so on.

Introspection is also our channel of self-knowledge. If you ask yourself what you are experiencing right now (say, in the lower part of your left leg), the beliefs you form will be the product of information in your brain's experience reports. And since that information is schematic, the beliefs will be of a simple, inarticulate form. You will judge that you are having an experience with a distinctive character and significance, which you immediately recognize but can't describe, except by comparison with other experiences. You will be inclined to say that the experience has a distinctive *feel* or *quality* to it, and that worldly properties appear to you in the form of these qualities.

What's more, you will tend to judge that you are aware of these qualities directly and with absolute certainty. When we ask ourselves what we're experiencing, we immediately find ourselves with strong beliefs on the matter. But we have no awareness of the introspective mechanisms responsible for generating these beliefs. (For that, we would need another layer of introspective processes, monitoring the first layer.) We just know we're feeling a pain in the shin, say, or tasting

coffee. Perception is similar, of course. When we look around us, we immediately form beliefs about what's there, without any awareness of the brain processes that produced them. There's a difference, however. With perception, we know that there *are* mechanisms involved; we know that we need eyes to see, ears to hear, and so on. With introspection, it is different. We don't even know that the mechanisms exist; they are hidden away in our brains. And since we know nothing of the mechanisms that produce our judgements about our experiences, we assume that there aren't any, and that the qualities of our experiences are presented to us directly, as if by magic.

For similar reasons, your beliefs about your experiences will seem to you certain. We know that our sense organs can mislead us about the world, and we have ways of checking the accuracy of the beliefs they produce. If you suspect that your eyes are playing tricks on you, you can ask someone else to take a look. With introspection it is quite different. We have no idea whether our introspective mechanisms can mislead us, and we have no way of checking their reliability. You can't get a friend to introspect your brain processes (though this might change with future technology). And since you have no way of questioning the beliefs introspection produces, you assume they are unquestion*able*. You might even take them to be the basis of all your empirical knowledge.

The upshot is that introspection systematically misleads us. Its impressionistic subpersonal reports on complex brain processes lead us to believe that we have direct and infallible awareness of simple phenomenal properties. This is the illusion in illusionism.

6. Two kinds of consciousness

In the picture I am sketching, then, there are two levels of consciousness, which we might call *perceptual* and *introspective*. Perceptual consciousness is the basic sort. It consists of sensory experiences of all kinds, in which information from the sense organs is processed, shared with control systems, and used to generate a host of reactions. Perceptual consciousness engages an organism directly with its environment and its own body in a complex, continually evolving loop of information and reaction, without any intervening awareness of mental qualities. It is not an all-or-nothing condition, and forms of it are probably widespread in the animal kingdom.

Introspective consciousness, on the other hand, is an inner awareness directed at one's own experiences. Introspective mechanisms track the informational and

reactive states involved in perceptual consciousness and produce highly schematic descriptions of them, which are used for purposes of communication and higher-level control. This tends to generate the illusion that experiences possess an indefinable what-it-is-likeness, which resists scientific explanation. I suspect that introspective consciousness is rare in the natural world and perhaps unique to humans.

Am I saying that the experiences of non-human animals are not *like anything* — that animals are just biological machines whose internal states don't matter? No. There are two things we might mean by saying that a creature's experiences are *like something*, and in neither sense does introspective consciousness make a difference. If we mean that the creature's experiences actually possess phenomenal properties, then no creatures have experiences that are like something, not even us. Introspection does not create phenomenal properties; it merely fosters belief in their existence. If, on the other hand, we mean that the creature's experiences possess features that would give rise to the illusion of phenomenality if they were introspected, then the experiences of many non-human animals *are* like something. Many such animals have experiences similar to ours, and if they were equipped with the apparatus of introspection and higher-level control, they would form similar beliefs about them. So even if introspective consciousness were unique to humans, there would be no sharp difference between what the experiences of human and nonhuman animals are like. Nor would it follow that the experiences of nonhuman animals did not matter. Although introspective consciousness confers important new abilities, I see no reason to think that it is necessary for possession of moral status and a claim on our compassion. Perceptual consciousness, I would argue, is sufficient for that. But that is a topic for another time.

7. Is illusionism coherent?

You may be feeling that there's something wrong here. Does illusionism really make sense? Many people think it doesn't. I shall mention a couple of common complaints.

First, isn't there a confusion in the very idea that experience itself could be illusory? Illusions occur when our senses deceive us about the things around us. But when this happens, we still have experiences *as of* the illusory things. So how could experience itself be an illusion? We'd have to have experiences as of the

illusory experiences, and those experiences themselves would still be real. The whole idea seems circular and self-defeating.

It shouldn't be too hard to guess how the illusionist will reply. The objection assumes that perceptual illusions involve awareness of mental qualities — that hallucinating a pink elephant involves being aware of a mental version of a pink elephant, displayed in the Cartesian Theatre. If that were so, then, by parallel, having the illusion of a mental quality would involve being aware of a mental version of that mental quality, displayed in a second Cartesian Theatre. This would indeed be circular. But of course, illusionists deny that perceptual illusions involve awareness of mental qualities. They hold that perception is a stream of subpersonal reports produced for the systems that control our reactions. When we are awake and all is going well, the reports are accurate and the reactions appropriate to our situation. Illusions occur when the reporting processes go awry and the reactions cease to be appropriate. And illusionists think of introspection in just the same way. Introspective mechanisms produce reports about our experiences, and introspective illusions occur when the reports are inaccurate or misleading in some way, tending to produce mistaken beliefs about the nature of our experiences. In each case, the illusion consists in a cluster of informational and reactive states, not in the qualities of an inner show.

A related objection involves asking who is the *subject* of the illusion. The thought is that an illusion requires a conscious observer, so if consciousness itself is an illusion, then there must be a further conscious observer to observe it. The illusionist response is similar to the previous one. Illusions do not require an inner observer, since there is no inner show to observe, just a set of reports about what is happening. It is true that some *consumer* is required for the reports, but this is the collection of control systems which use the information to guide their activities. These control systems are the consumers of both perceptual and introspective reports. The activity of these systems makes you (the organism, the person) finely sensitive to — and thus aware of — your environment and your own reactions to it.

8. They are real, dammit!

I have tried to give a sense of what illusionism is and why it is worth taking seriously. Still, you may feel, it just cannot be right. The feel of things — the redness of a ripe tomato, the taste of coffee, the pain of a bruised shin — these can't be

just a matter of *information*. They are too concrete, too vivid, too *present*. They are real, dammit!

That's a natural reaction — and one that is predicted by the illusionist theory itself. As we have seen, our judgements about our experiences will seem compelling in just this way, since they are produced by subpersonal mechanisms of which we have no awareness. Here I have given only an extremely simplified sketch of the processes involved, couched in metaphorical terms of reporting and suchlike. The full picture will be immensely complex, and it will take many years of scientific work to complete it. Illusionists believe that as we fill in the picture, mapping the vast, intricate, multi-layered web of informational and reactive processes, the gap between it and our personal impression of what is happening will diminish.

Here's another reason for thinking that we should distrust our impressions in this area. Suppose that consciousness did involve phenomenal properties — that when you look at a ripe tomato your brain did generate a mental redness. Still, how would that mental redness get to affect *you*? If it was to affect what you feel, think, say, or do, then it would have to have an impact on the brain systems that control those things. And that would require some mechanism that could detect it and send information about it to those systems. Brain systems are triggered by patterns of neuron firing, not by qualities. So even if it existed, phenomenal redness would affect you — the person — only through the *mediation* of subpersonal neural reporting. Your world is the product of this reporting and report consumption, and from your point of view everything would be the same whether the reports were true or false. The moral is that you cannot tell through introspection alone whether or not illusionism is true. It would all seem the same to you either way. So, if science has no need to posit phenomenal properties in constructing its picture of the mind, then the obvious inference is that they are illusory.

9. Coda

The next day, you are walking in the town when you spot the old woman again. She looks younger than she did, and you notice with a shock that her colourful dress is covered with images of beetles. Determined to solve the mystery, you approach and beg her to tell you how she made the beetle appear. She smiles. 'Oh, I didn't make anything appear', she says. 'You see, I'm a hypnotist. I simply hypnotized you into believing you'd seen a beetle in the box.'

You are left wondering. Was she telling the truth? Is it possible to hypnotize someone into believing they've seen things they haven't? What *really* happened

when you looked through the peephole in the box? You are going to have to think about this.[3]

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